

METHODOLOGY

The BT-Nielson survey was carried out in two phases. Face-to-face interviews were conducted with five groups of respondents including 120 MBA aspirants, 130 current MBAs (final year MBA students), 90 HR managers (with 2 to 3 years of work experience), 102 young executives (with 2 to 3 years of experience) and 105 functional heads (with 8 to 9 years of experience) making a total of 547 respondents across 12 cities—Delhi (including NCR), Mumbai, Kolkata, Chennai, Lucknow, Ahmedabad, Pune, Indore, Bangalore, Hyderabad, Patna and Coimbatore. In the first phase, a large sample of 853 respondents (comprising aspiring MBAs and recruiters) were polled to arrive at the top 30 B-schools. Respondents were then asked to rank these 30 schools on parameters such as reputation, placement, quality of placement, faculty, specialist units and admission eligibility. A brand equity score was arrived at for each of the 30 schools and the results compiled. *Business Today* (BT) is part of the India Today Group and Nielson is an independent marketing research organisation.



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the ranks for aspiring MBAs from 15 to 11 and Narsee Monjee Institute of Management Studies (NMIMS) from 20 to 15. At the same time, schools such as Management Development Institute (MDI), Gurgaon, Institute of Chartered Financial Analysts of India (ICFAI), Mumbai and T.A. Pai, Mumbai, lost in this category.

For the HR managers, IIM-B scored way higher than IIM-A except on the criterion of admission eligibility that gave IIM-A its final lead. Xavier Labour Relations Institute (XLRI), Jamshedpur, broke ahead of IIM-Calcutta and IIM-Lucknow with Symbiosis coming in a close third compared to last year's 11th spot for recruiters. One school that is catching up is Faculty of Management Studies (FMS), Delhi,

having broken into the top 10 again after a year's gap.

Speaking of its winning formula, NMIMS, which received 38,000 applications for 240 seats in its last academic year, believes nothing less than relentless effort at constant improvement is what makes for market value. One has to constantly portray to stakeholders that they matter and there is no let-up in efforts. The focus has now shifted to social entrepreneurship, elaborates Vice-Chancellor N.M. Kondap. No activity is disregarded and this is exemplified in the students' efforts to pick up supply-chain management tips from rag-pickers in the city.

Not every MBA graduate becomes a star performer. Only top 20 per cent of the 2,000 B-schools in the country get close to enabling, facilitating and delivering star performance. An ABC analysis of any MBA class reveals that only 20 per cent comprises star performers, 60 per cent are the steady growth category and the rest will probably switch fields.

Management programmes are becoming more rigorous and devoid of boundaries. Imagine, the case study of the General Shoe Company—the first-ever case study developed by Harvard Business School in 1921—is taken up and analysed for marketing, leadership, thought process change and financial management, letting students extrapolate as to how the company will perform in the current environment given a different political climate and economic setting. Another trend is revealed. If future leaders want to be the architects of their own destiny, they should be able to craft their own course structure, which means more agile programmes, fewer compulsory subjects and more electives. "These are a few things that have helped us progress," says K.T. Chacko, director, IIFT. Curriculum is more current, corporate social responsibility is no longer optional and students must work with NGOs. After all, no business can operate and hope to succeed in the real world without simultaneously tackling real problems. ■

The best colleges offer agile programmes, fewer compulsory subjects and more electives.